

Feedback for Coachees Guide

How to receive, process, and act on feedback effectively — a reception framework, emotional response guidance, processing techniques, and a way to turn feedback into real change.

1. Feedback Reception Framework

How you receive feedback in the moment shapes both what you actually absorb from it and whether you'll keep getting honest feedback in the future. A defensive reaction, even an understandable one, tends to teach people to soften or withhold what they tell you next time.

The Four-Step Framework

Step	What It Means
Listen Fully	Let the person finish completely before responding — resist formulating your defense while they're still talking
Clarify	Ask questions to understand specifically what they mean before reacting to what you assume they mean
Reflect	Take a moment — even a brief one — before responding, rather than reacting instantly while still processing
Respond	Thank them for raising it, even if it stings, and be honest about what you need time to think through versus what you can respond to now

Phrases That Help in the Moment

- *"Can you give me a specific example of that so I understand it fully?"*
- *"Thank you for telling me this — I want to think it through properly rather than respond right now."*
- *"I want to make sure I understood — what I'm hearing is..."*

2. Emotional Response Guide

A real emotional reaction to feedback — defensiveness, embarrassment, hurt, even anger — is a normal human response, not a sign you're handling it badly. The goal isn't to not feel it; it's to notice it without letting it drive your response.

Common Reactions and What They Often Mean

Reaction	What It Often Signals
Defensiveness	The feedback touched something you care about or have worked hard on — not necessarily that the feedback is wrong
Embarrassment	A gap between how you wanted to be seen and how you were actually seen in that moment
Anger	A sense that the feedback was unfair, poorly timed, or delivered without enough context — worth checking which of those it actually is
Relief	The feedback named something you already suspected but hadn't heard said out loud

Notice, Name, Pause

- Notice the physical sensation of the reaction (tight chest, warm face) as it happens, without judging it
- Name the emotion silently to yourself (“this is defensiveness”) — naming an emotion measurably reduces its intensity
- Pause before responding — the emotion and the feedback are two separate things, and you can acknowledge the first without it dictating your reaction to the second

If a particular kind of feedback consistently triggers a much stronger reaction than the situation seems to call for, that pattern itself can be worth exploring further with a coach or therapist — not because something is wrong with you, but because understanding why can make future feedback conversations genuinely easier.

3. Processing Techniques

Real processing usually happens after the conversation has ended, not during it — give yourself that time deliberately rather than expecting a final verdict on the spot.

The 24-Hour Rule

Don't decide whether feedback is valid, or how you'll respond to it, in the heat of the moment. Give it at least a day. Feedback that still feels important and accurate after the initial emotional charge has faded usually is; feedback that feels much smaller a day later often was reflecting the moment more than a real pattern.

Journaling Prompts

- What specifically was said, separate from how I interpreted it?
- Is there a kernel of truth here, even if the delivery or framing felt off?
- Has anyone else, ever, said something similar to me — even gently or indirectly?
- What would change if I assumed this feedback was accurate, just for the sake of considering it?

Separating Data from Identity

Feedback is information about a specific behavior or outcome, observed by one person, at one point in time. It is not a complete verdict on who you are. Treating it as data to weigh, rather than as a judgment to accept or reject wholesale, makes it much easier to actually use.

4. Integration and Action Steps

Feedback only creates change once it becomes a specific action — processed but unused feedback quietly disappears within a few weeks.

Guidance

- Choose one thing to focus on at a time, even if the feedback covered several — trying to change everything at once usually means changing nothing well
- Define what success actually looks like specifically, not just “improve at X”
- Identify one person who can give you honest, ongoing signal on whether it's actually changing
- Set a real check-in date, not just an open-ended intention to “keep working on it”

Your Integration Plan

Feedback Received	My Initial Reaction	What's Actionable	My Plan	Check-in Date
Example: “You tend to talk over people in meetings when you're excited about an idea”	Defensive, then embarrassed once I thought about it	Pause for two seconds before speaking in group discussions	Ask a trusted colleague to give me a subtle signal if it happens in our next few meetings together	In 3 weeks

Revisit this plan at your check-in date honestly — if it didn't change, that's useful information too, not a failure to note and move past quietly.